

mony for a child). They are also leading a quiet movement to perform upnayam (sacred thread ceremony) for women as per ancient practices. In today's times, only Brahmins can conduct such a ceremony. "Neighbours look at us as if we are strange creatures. Some respect us, some resist what we do," says Sanjivini Anand, a Shastri (graduation) student who hails from Deoria. Adds Pratibha, another student: "Sometimes, Pundit Varg (class) is either angry or surprised but gradually we are being accepted and respected in our areas."

The day begins early at dawn with prayers, followed by recitation of mantras, shlokas, martial arts training and exercises. The girls undergo a rig-

CHANTING HYMNS AND LEARNING TO FIGHT HELP STUDENTS TURN INTO 'PERFECT WOMEN'. THEY ARE TAUGHT TO PERFORM ALL IMPORTANT HINDU RITES, FROM VIVAHO TO ANTYESHTI.



Acharya Dharma Yachika, opened a Sanskrit school for girls at Sirohi, Rajasthan, while Dr Pushpalata Garg set up the Yog Sadhna Ashram at Papunagar in Jaipur. Vasudha Shastri, an ex-student, works as an Updeshika (preacher) in Hyderabad. About 50 former students of the college now teach the scriptures across the country. In 2002, four students went to Berlin on a government scholarship as experts of the Vedas. In March, Dharamvati Arya, a student, was selected by Tata Archery Academy and was sent to JRD Tata Sports Complex for advanced training.

After Varanasi, Pune is taking the lead in training women pundits. The city began to allow women into priesthood in the early 1980s when Shankarrao Thatte, the owner of a marriage hall, set up the Shankar Seva Samiti, a school to train female priests. The male priests' aloofness during religious ceremonies had prompted him to start a four-month course for women. Pune now has two such schools, Samiti and Jnana Prabodhini.

To further the cause of women priests, a temple, Panini Mandiram, is being built on the campus of the college at a cost of Rs 7 crore. It is being designed on the lines of south Indian temples and will have 4,000 sutras from holy scriptures engraved on its marble walls. For women priests who have lived in the shadows for over many centuries, this is a new beginning. ■

orous routine for 13 years at the college to attain priesthood, enrolling when they are between nine and 11 years old. Their journey into Sanskrit and the scriptures starts with Prathama, followed by Purv Madhyama, a two-year secondary course. Then comes another two-year stint at Uttar Madhyama, the intermediate level; a three-year Shastri (graduation); two years of Acharya (post-graduation) and finally Vidya Variki (Ph.D). The school section of the institute follows the ancient Gurukul

Agra-shishya Shiksha Pranali (senior students teaching their juniors). The school's mission is also to restore the ancient curriculum of gurukuls by teaching Astadhyayi and Mahashaya as well as the Vedas.

The first four students who dedicated their lives to this institution include Acharya Nandita Shastri, Dr Priyamvada, Dr Madu Rani and Acharya Surya Devi. Dr Priyamvada later opened a similar school in Najibabad. Another graduate,